

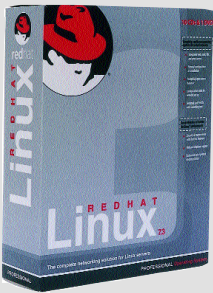
Bazaar

We test the latest and the best hardware and software products available in the market

Red Hat Linux 7.3

It costs a measly 11 grand!

Red Hat's latest version is a complete Linux package consisting of three base installation disks, one documentation CD, and StarOffice 5.2, Server and Productivity Application CDs, and a visiting card sized System Administrator's disk. All this also comes neatly packed within a single DVD. The package also includes three detailed manuals, including a Getting Started Guide, Reference Guide and Customisation Guide.



We installed Red Hat on a PC with a Pentium III 1.2 GHz processor, an 815EE chipset-based motherboard, 256 MB SDRAM and a 20 GB hard disk. We did not face any hardware compatibility issues with the onboard audio and video, and the monitor (Samtron 55E) was detected effortlessly. The base installation can range between 1.5 GB to 3 GB depending on the packages

you wish to install. After asking the standard questions about the keyboard, language preferences and mouse, Red Hat 7.3 offers a variety of installation classes including Server, Workstation, Laptop, Custom and an upgrade option for previous versions of Red Hat.

Once you've selected the class of installation, the next step is disk partitioning, which is handled by the powerful Disk Druid utility. Ironically, this utility is available only during disk partition. Disk Druid supports only ext2, ext3 and vfat (Virtual File Allocation Table) file systems, whereas Fdisk supports more than 80 different file types, including FAT16, BSD, DRDOS and HPFS.

The next few installation steps take you to the Boot Loader Configuration screen, where you can choose either GRUB or LILO to set up the Bootup Menu. Next, you configure the network and firewall. Here you can specify a default security level, trusted devices and types of incoming connections and ports, among other things. The last few installation steps include selecting the language, packages and configuring your video card and monitor.

For office productivity, you have KWord, KSpread and Kpresenter for word

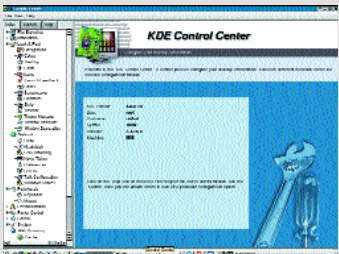
processing, spreadsheets and presentations, respectively. If software development is your forte, Red Hat packs around 75 programming tools and languages such as Perl, Guile, Python, etc.

The core Red Hat 7.3 distribution is based on the 2.4.18-3 kernel, and provides patched versions of popular Linux software with some interesting new additions. It includes glibc, XFree86, KDE, GNOME, emacs, Ghostscript, BIND, Sendmail, MySQL, PostgreSQL, PH and Apache.

Connecting to the Internet through dial-up was easy. We managed to set up a generic 56K modem, configure connection parameters and connect to the ISP in just a few minutes.

This distribution has a lot of features mimicking Windows such as screen-savers, desktop themes, sound support, multimedia, etc. It has X-Chat for chatting and supports audio CDs with a Winamp-like application called XMMS. On the

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Use the KDE Control Center to configure the GUI

browser front, Netscape, Mozilla, Galeon, KDE's Konqueror and GNOME's Nautilus complete the package—Konqueror and Nautilus are more like file managers that happen to understand URLs. Konqueror helps users to view even the hidden Windows folders whereas Nautilus does not.

With its treasure box of applications, Red Hat 7.3 caters to everyone, from home users looking at an easy-to-use Windows replacement OS, to those looking for a powerful Web server OS.

SPECIFICATIONS

System Requirements:
Pentium class processor, 650 MB disk space, 32 MB RAM

Red Hat Linux 7.3		B+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶	
Ease of use	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	